



Boundary spanner multi-faceted role ambiguity and burnout: An exploratory study [☆]



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ABSTRACT

Although researchers have gained considerable knowledge regarding the multi-faceted manifestation of burnout over recent years, inconsistent findings of role ambiguity as an antecedent to burnout are still prevalent. Given the complex boundary-spanning nature of sales, it is likely that global measures of role ambiguity fail to fully capture the domain and impact of role ambiguity. To help address this gap, this study provides initial evidence that facets of role ambiguity impact burnout manifestation in the sales role differently. Specifically, findings provide a foundation to help mitigate the negative impact of burnout by focusing on only certain facets of role ambiguity.

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1. Introduction

Despite a resurgence of interest in salesperson burnout (e.g. Hollet-Haudebert, Mulki, & Fournier, 2011; Shepherd, Tashchian, & Ridnour, 2011), little is known about the antecedents of the sequenced facets of burnout. Given that the sequencing of burnout is different for employees working in the sales field compared to workers outside of the sales field (Lewin & Sager, 2007), findings from other disciplines (e.g. health care, teaching, and social services) are not generalizable in sales. Burnout has existed as a term in the lexicon of popular culture since the 1970s when psychoanalyst, Herbert Freudenberg (1974), used burnout to describe a general condition of negativity, cynicism, and diminished job interest he witnessed among co-workers (Shepherd et al., 2011). Job burnout has been established as a unique form of stress that is distinguished from depression and can be empirically measured (Cordes & Dougherty, 1993; Maslach & Leiter, 2008). It is widely believed

that job-centered burnout is especially prevalent among boundary-spanning positions in which workers have to interact with multiple constituencies and navigate conflicting agendas (Cordes & Dougherty, 1993; Parkington & Schneider, 1979). Furthermore, burnout is very costly for firms manifesting in absenteeism, increased medical costs, and reduced productivity (Lewin & Sager, 2009).

One antecedent linked to burnout is role ambiguity (e.g. Babakus, Cravens, Johnston, & Moncrief, 1999; Rutherford, Hamwi, Friend, & Hartmann, 2011). However, role ambiguity has exhibited mixed results as a predictor of burnout (e.g. Boles, Johnston, & Hair, 1997; Hollet-Haudebert et al., 2011), and other outcomes such as job satisfaction (e.g. Babakus et al., 1999; Boles et al., 1997; Rutherford et al., 2011) and performance (e.g. Babakus et al., 1999; Low, Cravens, Grant, & Moncrief, 2001). From a research perspective, this inconsistency suggests that role ambiguity in a salesperson context needs further scrutiny. From a practitioner perspective, it is important for researchers to shed light on the most problematic sources of ambiguity that warrant managerial attention.

Discrepancies may be due to an array of issues within the conceptual and methodological domains of both role ambiguity and burnout. Recent studies have made considerable advances in the conceptual and methodological domains of burnout (Lewin & Sager, 2007; Rutherford et al., 2011); hopefully, providing the basis to eliminate the use of single facet studies of burnout that only examine the emotional exhaustion facet (e.g. Hamwi, Rutherford, & Boles, 2011; Lewin & Sager, 2009; Rutherford, Boles, Hamwi, Madupalli, & Rutherford, 2009;

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Sager, Strutton, & Johnson, 2006). While emotional exhaustion is a hallmark symptom of burnout, there are two other facets (i.e. lack of personal accomplishment and depersonalization) that also serve as markers of the syndrome's progression.

Unfortunately, research on salesperson role ambiguity has not made the same level of advancement as burnout despite early attempts to various types of ambiguity such as uncertainty experienced with customers and co-workers (Rhoads, Singh, & Goodell, 1994; Singh & Rhoads, 1991). Within sales, role ambiguity research suffers from several limitations: 1) issues with assessing both role ambiguity and role conflict as antecedents to the same outcome, 2) an entire reverse coded scale often used for measurement (e.g. Rizzo, House, & Lirtzman, 1970), and 3) a lack of understanding of role ambiguity as either a global or a multi-faceted construct (see Churchill, Ford, & Walker, 1974 for issues with global measures). According to the IMP research tradition, actors maintain multi-faceted identities within larger networks (Cantù, Corsaro, Fiocca, & Tunisini, 2013; Håkansson, Ford, Gadde, Snehota, & Waluszewski, 2009). These multi-faceted identities are subject to ambiguity stemming from multiple sources. Sales researchers have yet to embrace the multi-dimensionality of role ambiguity that is inherent in boundary-spanning positions.

To address these issues and further our understanding of role ambiguity within the sales literature, the purpose of this study is to identify relationships at the facet level between role ambiguity and burnout in relation to job satisfaction and performance while controlling for role conflict (see Fig. 1). Findings for this study will: 1) shed light on why results using global measures of role ambiguity in sales research have been inconclusive; 2) further explain the process model of burnout for sales; 3) demonstrate that some facets of role ambiguity matter more than others; and 4) provide prescriptive advice for managers in warding off burnout and thus aiding in job satisfaction and performance.

2. Role theory

Role theory as a research domain encompasses several sub-domains and includes knowledge development across many disciplines (Thomas & Biddle, 1966). In one of the earliest attempts to provide scope for role theory and summarize prior study findings, Thomas and Biddle (1966) frame the sub-domain of conflict as one endpoint on a continuum that has consensus on the opposite end. Conflict and ambiguity have been recognized to cause stress; thus, within larger role theory, “role stress” has largely come to encapsulate three types: 1) role conflict is the

degree of incompatibility associated with role expectations; 2) role ambiguity is the degree to which clear information and expectations are lacking; and 3) role overload is the degree to which expectations exceed individual's abilities and motivation to perform tasks (Cordes & Dougherty, 1993; Singh, Goolsby, & Rhoads, 1994).

Research has focused heavily on role conflict and role ambiguity as the main stressors associated with managing relationships, a primary focus of the sales profession (Babakus et al., 1999; Boles et al., 1997; Lewin & Sager, 2009; Rutherford et al., 2011). Recognition of potential for high levels of role stress in professional sales traces all the way back to the work of Kahn, Wolfe, Quinn, Snoek, and Rosenthal (1964) which acknowledged that boundary-spanning positions face pressures not only within and across departments but from outside the organization as well. Global measures for role stressors were subsequently developed (Rizzo et al., 1970), and role stress has received considerable interest in marketing for its ability to better understand outcomes such as job satisfaction, performance, and turnover (Behrman & Perreault, 1984; Johnson, Griffeth, & Griffin, 2000; Singh et al., 1994; Walker, Churchill, & Ford, 1975).

3. Construct overview

3.1. Role ambiguity

3.1.1. Defining role ambiguity

As one of the core types of role stress, Kahn et al. (1964) define role ambiguity as a “direct function of the discrepancy between the information available to the person and that which is required for adequate performance of his role” (p. 73). In the present study, role ambiguity is the focal antecedent to burnout for several reasons. First, role ambiguity is an important aspect of role theory and has exhibited the most inconsistent findings among the role stress constructs (Shepherd & Fine, 1994; Singh & Rhoads, 1991). Next, the global measure for role ambiguity is lacking in its breadth and ability to capture the various underlying facets of ambiguity (King & King, 1990; Rhoads et al., 1994; Singh & Rhoads, 1991). Unlike burnout research, progress has not occurred in the sales literature to identify relationships at the facet level of role ambiguity. Last, role ambiguity is a factor of role stress that management is most likely to be able to positively impact (Singh & Rhoads, 1991). In fact, Walker et al. (1975) note that the right organizational structure and management styles can help salespeople to minimize role ambiguity, but cannot reduce the degree of role conflict salespeople experience.

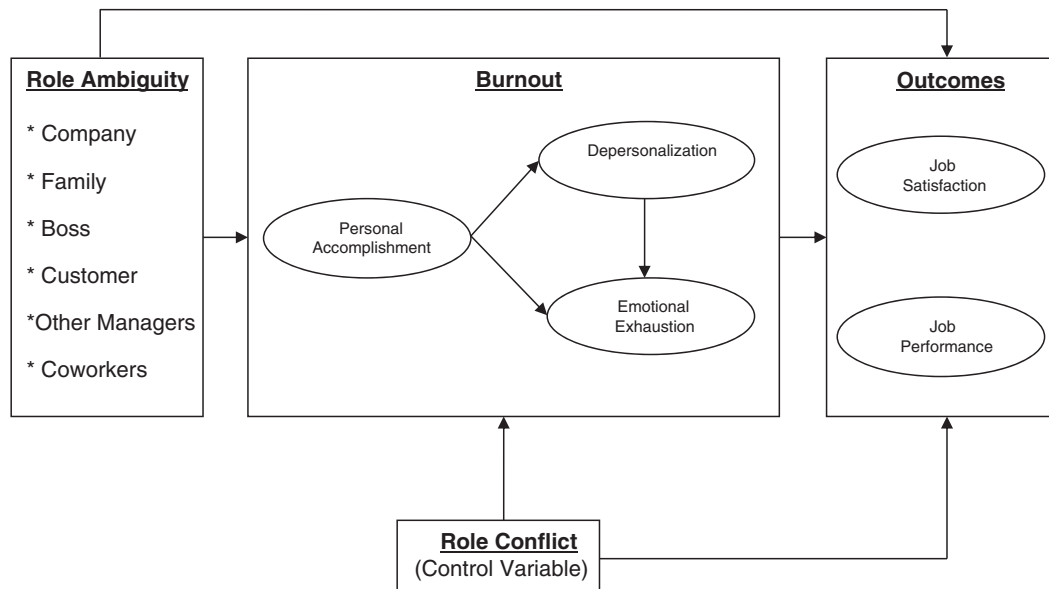


Fig. 1. The salesperson burnout model.

3.1.2. Multi-faceted role ambiguity

Singh and Rhoads (1991) in recognition of the shortcomings of the role ambiguity global measure developed a 45-item multidimensional, multifaceted role ambiguity construct called MULTIRAM to be used for boundary-spanning positions. The scale items were aggregated at the facet level designed to measure ambiguity in seven key areas: company (flexibility, work, promotion), boss (support, demands), customer (interaction, objection, presentation), ethical (internal, external), other managers, coworkers, and family. A subsequent study using the MULTIRAM scale and an industrial field sales force investigated role ambiguity in direct relation to various outcome measures including job satisfaction and performance (Rhoads et al., 1994). The various facets were categorized and tested according to internal and external dimensions of salesperson ambiguity. Internal facets encompass: company, boss, internal-ethical, other managers, and coworkers; whereas, external facets encompass customer, external-ethical, and family. Given the richness and complexity of work roles and relationships that boundary-spanners encounter, the global role ambiguity measure was seen as incapable of capturing this richness given its lack of dimensional breadth (King & King, 1990; Shepherd & Fine, 1994; Singh & Rhoads, 1991). Yet, the global measure has continued to be used in salesperson research exclusively with inconsistent findings (Boles et al., 1997; Hollet-Haudebert et al., 2011; Lewin & Sager, 2007; Rutherford et al., 2011).

3.2. Burnout

3.2.1. Defining burnout

Burnout is a multi-dimensional construct consisting of three facets: emotional exhaustion, depersonalization, and personal accomplishment (Maslach & Jackson, 1981). The seminal work of Maslach and Jackson (1981) identified these three facets as subscale measurements of an instrument that came to be known as the Maslach Burnout Inventory. Emotional exhaustion is described as a condition in which worker's psychological resources have been depleted to the point that they are no longer able to give of themselves. Exhaustion represents the most obvious manifestation of the stress component of burnout. Depersonalization is described as a dysfunctional coping mechanism induced by job-related stress that causes workers to become callous, distant, and negative in the direction of others. Descriptions of the depersonalization facet have labeled it as cynicism (Angerer, 2003; Maslach, Schaufeli, & Leiter, 2001). The last facet, originally labeled in a positive fashion as feelings of personal accomplishment, has typically been reverse-coded by sales researchers to reflect reduced personal accomplishment or inefficacy (Angerer, 2003; Rutherford et al., 2011). It is a feeling of dejection expressed by workers that are no longer accomplishing their goals and have lost confidence in their abilities to perform adequately at work (Maslach & Jackson, 1981).

3.2.2. Burnout research in a sales context

Salesperson burnout research gained traction following the seminal review of Cordes and Dougherty (1993) who suggested that several professions involving significant communication with clients and boundary-spanning activities were likely susceptible to burnout. One of the first marketing studies to incorporate the burnout construct, as defined by Maslach and Jackson (1981), involved customer service representatives (Singh et al., 1994). The authors found that burnout was higher in customer service representatives compared to many of the burnout-prone occupations previously studied including police work, teaching, and nursing. Singh et al. (1994) also reported that burnout served as a partial mediator between role stressors and job performance.

A considerable portion of salesperson research has focused exclusively on the emotional exhaustion facet of burnout (e.g. Babakus et al., 1999; Boles et al., 1997; Hamwi et al., 2011; Lewin & Sager, 2009; Rutherford et al., 2009; Sager et al., 2006). Although emotional exhaustion is an important component of burnout, it has also been

reasoned that the length of the original survey instrument may be prohibitively long causing researchers to use only the emotional exhaustion subscale in neglect of depersonalization and reduced personal accomplishment (Rutherford et al., 2011).

3.2.3. Sequencing of burnout

The path sequencing of the burnout construct in this study is conceptualized keeping with the findings of Lewin and Sager (2007), specific to a salesperson context. Lewin and Sager (2007) challenged both the Maslach and Golembiewski models of burnout sequencing for salespeople (Golembiewski, 1989; Golembiewski & Munzenrider, 1981, 1984, 1988; Maslach, 1978, 1982; Leiter & Maslach, 1988; Leiter & Meechan, 1986). The authors noted that the sales profession differs from the helping professions on a number of measures that are important to consider. The rewards and stressors of the helping professions usually stem from client interactions; whereas, the rewards of salespeople may stem from exceeding sales quotas, and the stressors may originate from not being able to meet productivity goals or quotas. Potentially more in line with the sales profession, Lewin and Sager (2007) found that burnout followed a non-linear progression starting with reduced personal accomplishment, leading to depersonalization as one tries to attribute the lack of accomplishment to external forces, ultimately leading to emotional exhaustion as despair sets in.

3.3. Job satisfaction

Psychological outcomes typically include such measures as job satisfaction, commitment, and turnover intentions (Singh et al., 1994). These measures encompass attitudes and the psychological approach toward the job. Answering calls to further define job satisfaction for each occupation, Churchill et al. (1974) define job satisfaction as "all characteristics of the job itself and the work environment which industrial salesmen find rewarding, fulfilling, and satisfying, or frustrating and unsatisfying" (p. 255). Job satisfaction has been a common outcome studied in salesperson burnout research (Babakus et al., 1999; Boles et al., 1997; Low et al., 2001; Rutherford et al., 2011).

3.4. Job performance

In the boundary-spanner role, researchers are primarily focused on performance outcomes that involve some assessment of effectiveness with customers (Singh et al., 1994). Typical performance assessments will include both behavioral and outcome measures (Babakus et al., 1999; Behrman & Perreault, 1984). Behavioral aspects include strategies and job activities that salespeople engage in as part of the process of meeting customer needs and wants (Babakus et al., 1999). One such measure is determining the effectiveness of sales presentations given to customers and prospects. Outcome measures are results-based in order to assess the link between effective behavioral tasks such as making effective sales presentations and desirable outcomes achieved. Such assessments may include achieving annual sales targets and achieving objectives linked to cost control.

4. Hypothesis development

4.1. Linking role ambiguity to burnout

The lack of previous research renders the task of specifying hypotheses at the facet levels of role ambiguity and burnout difficult and, at best, exploratory. As such, facets will be tested as shown in Fig. 1 and subsequently reported (see Tables 1 and 2). In one of the early studies on salesperson burnout, Verbeke (1997) found a relationship between role ambiguity and personal accomplishment along with the other two facets of burnout. In subsequent studies, the global measure of role ambiguity was also found to be related to the personal accomplishment facet of burnout (Lewin & Sager, 2007; Rutherford et al., 2011).

Table 1

Correlations, means, standard deviations, and reliabilities.

Variables	X1	X2	X3	X4	X5	X6	X7	X8	X9	X10	X11	X12	X13	Mean (S.D.)
RA Work (X1) ^a	.80													1.96 (.774)
RA promo (X2) ^a	.403*	.81												2.72 (1.09)
RA family (X3)	.287*	.257*	.86											2.20 (.79)
RA boss (X4)	.453*	.586*	.290*	.91										2.20 (.86)
RA cust (X5)	.388*	.267*	.280*	.424*	.87									1.82 (.67)
RA other (X6)	.382*	.466*	.367*	.559*	.415*	.90								2.70 (.95)
RA cowo (X7)	.419*	.407*	.251*	.539*	.485*	.492*	.86							2.08 (.73)
Pers accom (X8)	-.129	-.262*	-.122	-.363*	-.282*	-.310*	-.208*	.83						5.51 (1.29)
EE (X9)	.259*	.304*	.232*	.344*	.369*	.342*	.256*	-.428*	.89					3.96 (1.54)
Deper (X10)	.188*	.190*	.163*	.241*	.371*	.228*	.192*	-.326*	.560*	.80				2.21 (1.27)
Role con (X11)	.317*	.299*	.141*	.442*	.180*	.226*	.283*	-.282*	.332*	.351*	.76			2.44 (.89)
Job sat (X12)	-.321*	-.368*	-.236*	-.464*	-.380*	-.330*	-.272*	.517*	-.541*	-.284*	-.298*	.93		2.94 (1.49)
Job perf (X13)	-.305*	-.197*	-.200*	-.195*	-.441*	-.342*	-.246*	.217*	-.332*	-.220*	-.073	.315*	.81	3.66 (.87)

RA work = role ambiguity with work; RA promo = role ambiguity with promotion; RA family = role ambiguity with family; RA boss = role ambiguity with boss; RA cust = role ambiguity with customers; RA other = role ambiguity with other managers; RA COWO = role ambiguity with coworkers; Pers accom = personal accomplishment; EE = emotional exhaustion; Deper = depersonalization; Role con = role conflict; Job sat = job satisfaction; Job per = job performance.

Reliabilities are on the diagonal.

* Significant correlation at the .05 level.

^a Results from exploratory factor analysis indicate that the role ambiguity facet of company broke down into two unique dimensions consistent with MULTIRAM's work and promotion dimensions.

However, in a business-to-consumer setting, role ambiguity was not significantly related to personal accomplishment (Hollet-Haudebert et al., 2011).

In developing the MULTIRAM measurement instrument, it was determined that the global measure of role ambiguity as developed by Rizzo et al. (1970) aligned closely to the company and boss facets of role ambiguity (Rhoads et al., 1994; Singh & Rhoads, 1991). The authors argued that inconsistent role ambiguity findings may be partially explained due to the global measure only correlating closely with these two facets, thus, not accounting for other key dimensions of ambiguity. Given the partial support for a relationship in salesperson burnout literature between role ambiguity (global measure) and personal accomplishment, it can be reasoned that certain facets of role ambiguity are related to personal accomplishment. Thus, we hypothesize:

H1. There is a negative relationship between role ambiguity facets and personal accomplishment.

Salesperson studies which include role ambiguity as a predictor of depersonalization are sparse. Rutherford et al. (2011) found a relationship between role ambiguity and depersonalization; yet, in another study involving a business-to-consumer salesperson sample, role ambiguity was not found to be related to depersonalization (Hollet-Haudebert et al., 2011). The depersonalization facet of burnout measures the distancing of oneself from customers. Salespeople score highly on the depersonalization measure as they become callous, cynical, and disconnected from customers. At the very least, role ambiguity related to customers is likely to be directly related to depersonalization. It is also possible that other facets of role ambiguity are significantly related to depersonalization. Thus, we hypothesize:

H2. There is a positive relationship between role ambiguity facets and depersonalization.

Role ambiguity as a direct predictor of emotional exhaustion has found support in the literature using the global measure (e.g. Babakus et al., 1999; Lewin & Sager, 2009; Rutherford et al., 2011). Conversely, Boles et al. (1997) did not find a significant relationship between role ambiguity and emotional exhaustion. The authors hinted at the potential complexity of role ambiguity noting that the relationship may have been attenuated with the work–family conflict construct that was included in their study. As with the personal accomplishment facet, given that there is a partial support for a relationship in the salesperson burnout literature between role ambiguity (global measure) and emotional exhaustion, it can be reasoned that one of the facets between

company and boss is related to emotional exhaustion since these are the facets that the global measure is most likely capturing (Rhoads et al., 1994; Singh & Rhoads, 1991). In addition, several of the items on the emotional exhaustion scale make reference to one's work or job. Therefore, multiple facets of role ambiguity may be directly related to emotional exhaustion and need to be tested. Thus, we hypothesize:

H3. There is a positive relationship between role ambiguity facets and emotional exhaustion.

4.2. Predicting job satisfaction

Sales literature is also mixed regarding the direct relationship of role ambiguity as a global measure and the outcome job satisfaction. A significant negative relationship has been found between role ambiguity and job satisfaction (Babakus et al., 1999; Low et al., 2001). Conversely, Boles et al. (1997) did not find a relationship between role ambiguity and job satisfaction. However, compared to a complete lack of facet-level research of role ambiguity with burnout; facet-level role ambiguity has been sparsely studied with outcome measures such as job satisfaction and job performance. Rhoads et al. (1994) reported on these relationships using the MULTIRAM scale and an industrial-based sales force. In exploratory fashion, the authors posited that job satisfaction represents a psychological state that is more likely to align with internal facets of role ambiguity. It was theorized that inadequate information, internal to the organization, is the main-based stressor impacting satisfaction. Rhoads et al. (1994) largely found this to be the case with the exception of customer (externally-based) ambiguity displaying significance as well. It is important to determine if there is additional support for these results. Thus, we offer the following hypothesis in efforts to replicate their findings:

H4. There is a negative relationship between role ambiguity facets and job satisfaction.

4.3. Predicting job performance

A second outcome commonly studied in the salesperson literature is job performance. Once again, role ambiguity as a direct predictor of job performance has exhibited inconsistent findings. Using a combination of business-to-business and business-to-consumer sales representatives based in Australia, a negative direct relationship was determined between role ambiguity and performance (Low et al., 2001). On the

Table 2
The results.

Hypotheses	Linkages	Unstandardized coefficient	Significant/not significant
H1	Antecedents of personal accomplishment:		
	RA work	.216	Not significant
	RA promotion	−.082	Not significant
	RA family	.040	Not significant
	RA boss	−.294	Significant
	RA customer	−.353	Significant
	RA other managers	−.194	Not significant
	RA co-workers	.127	Not significant
H2	Role conflict	−.246	Significant
	Antecedents of depersonalization:		
	RA work	−.025	Not significant
	RA promotion	.042	Not significant
	RA family	.068	Not significant
	RA boss	−.129	Not significant
	RA customer	.588	Significant
	RA other managers	.024	Not significant
	RA co-workers	−.100	Not significant
	Role conflict	.402	Significant
H3	Personal accomplishment	−.183	Significant
	Antecedents of emotional exhaustion:		
	RA work	.079	Not significant
	RA promotion	.108	Not significant
	RA family	.111	Not significant
	RA boss	.002	Not significant
	RA customer	.181	Significant (indirectly)
	RA other managers	.124	Not significant
	RA co-workers	−.040	Not significant
	Role conflict	.106	Significant (indirectly)
H4	Personal accomplishment	−.247	Significant
	Depersonalization	.480	Significant
	Antecedents of job satisfaction:		
	RA work	−.173	Not significant
	RA promotion	−.096	Not significant
	RA family	−.083	Not significant
	RA boss	−.311	Significant
	RA customer	−.270	Significant (indirectly)
	RA other managers	.098	Not significant
	RA co-workers	.131	Not significant
H5	Role conflict	−.028	Not significant
	Personal accomplishment	.344	Significant
	Depersonalization	.132	Not significant
	Emotional exhaustion	−.335	Significant
	Antecedents of job performance:		
	RA work	−.178	Significant
	RA promotion	−.017	Not significant
	RA family	−.014	Not significant
	RA boss	.159	Not significant
	RA customer	−.400	Significant
	RA other managers	−.167	Significant
	RA co-workers	.021	Not significant
	Role conflict	.082	Not significant
	Personal accomplishment	.042	Not significant
	Depersonalization	.013	Not significant
	Emotional exhaustion	−.098	Significant

other hand, using a business-to-business sales force exclusively did not yield a significant relationship between role ambiguity and job performance (Babakus et al., 1999). Rhoads et al. (1994) theorized that job performance is more of a behavioral measure than job satisfaction and that it would more closely align with external facets. Ambiguity related to sales specific tasks as opposed to administrative matters would more likely impact performance in a negative fashion. Rhoads et al. (1994) found support for this external impact on job performance through the customer facet. Therefore, we offer the following hypothesis in efforts to expand and replicate their findings:

H5. There is a negative relationship between role ambiguity facets and job performance.

Theorizing that progressive levels of ambiguity would trigger the onset of burnout, which in turn would further reduce job satisfaction

and performance, Singh et al. (1994) did establish that burnout partially mediates these relationships. However, this partial mediation effect was established using a sample of customer service representatives and neither role ambiguity nor burnout were assessed at the component level. Confirmation of the partial mediation thesis was subsequently provided using a salesperson sample and testing relationships at the facet level of burnout with global measures of role stressors (Verbeke, 1997). Also, focusing on one component of burnout only, Babakus et al. (1999) found that emotional exhaustion facilitates the relationship between role stressors and outcomes, but not to the extent that Singh et al. (1994) witnessed in a customer service context. The potential mediating role of early burnout facets, sequenced in a salesperson context, between individual role ambiguity facets and subsequent burnout facets has not been investigated. Furthermore, the potential mediating influence of burnout between individual role ambiguity facets and outcome

measures of job satisfaction and job performance has yet to be investigated. However, previous findings for the partial mediation thesis at the aggregate level provide tentative support that some mediation is also likely to occur at the facet level. Thus, we offer the following exploratory hypotheses:

H6. Burnout facets will partially mediate linkages between role ambiguity facets and subsequent facets of burnout.

H7. Burnout will partially mediate linkages between role ambiguity facets and job satisfaction.

H8. Burnout will partially mediate linkages between role ambiguity facets and job performance.

4.4. Controlling for role conflict

Role conflict as an antecedent to salesperson burnout has shown more consistent results compared to role ambiguity. The global measure of role conflict has repeatedly been found to be related to emotional exhaustion in prior studies (e.g. Babakus et al., 1999; Boles et al., 1997; Hamwi et al., 2011; Lewin & Sager, 2007; Lewin & Sager, 2009; Rutherford et al., 2011). Similarly, role conflict has shown a consistent relationship to depersonalization (e.g. Hollet-Haudebert et al., 2011; Rutherford et al., 2011; Singh et al., 1994; Verbeke, 1997). Conversely, role conflict has not been found to be related to personal accomplishment (Hollet-Haudebert et al., 2011; Rutherford et al., 2011; Singh et al., 1994). The hypothesis development will remain focused on multi-faceted role ambiguity with role conflict serving as a control when predicting burnout, job satisfaction, and job performance.

5. Methodology

5.1. Sample

Questionnaires were mailed to a total of 2300 salespeople obtained from industry and commercial list sources representing a variety of organizations throughout the United States. Respondents came from several major industry categories including retail (25%), services (22%), wholesale (13%), and manufacturing of consumer and industrial goods (10%). Seventy-eight questionnaires were returned due to incomplete or no forwarding addresses. Ultimately, two hundred and forty-nine questionnaires were returned, this number was further reduced to 226 based on listwise deletion resulting in a response rate of 11%. The selling experience ranged from 1 to 45 years with a mean of 12.3 years. Male respondents account for 64% of the sample and the average age is 38.2 years. Furthermore, respondents have worked for an average of 6.5 years with their current employer. No significant differences were found between early and late respondents regarding demographic characteristics or response patterns.

5.2. Measures

Scales in the extant literature were used for measuring all of the identified constructs. Role ambiguity was measured using the 45-item MULTIRAM instrument (Singh & Rhoads, 1991). The ethical facet of MULTIRAM was not included in order to reduce study complexity. Ethics has rarely been incorporated into research directly focused on salesperson burnout and it is not germane to our study. Role conflict was assessed using the common 8-item instrument developed by Rizzo et al. (1970). Burnout was assessed using the reduced Maslach burnout inventory for sales (Rutherford et al., 2011). The job satisfaction construct was measured using a three-item scale developed by Netemeyer, Boles, McKee, and McMurrian (1997). Finally, job performance was measured by four items evaluating if annual sales targets and objectives have been met, effectiveness of presentations, having

adequate product knowledge, and understanding both customer needs and work processes. Table 1 provides correlations, means, standard deviations, and reliabilities of all constructs and Table 2 reports the significance of the proposed linkages.

5.3. Method

A confirmatory factor analysis was conducted using LISREL. Items that fit poorly on their constructs were removed from the analysis. The resulting measurement model contained 51 items with at least 3 items per construct. The overall model suggested good fit according to the standards set forth by Hu and Bentler (1999) and by Hair, Black, Babin, and Anderson (2010) (chi-square of 1815 with 1146 degrees of freedom; SRMR = .055; RMSEA = .051; CFI = .98). All items had significant loadings and demonstrated convergent and discriminant validity. Average variance extracted from each construct ranged between .52 and .82. Next, multiple regression was used to test the hypothesized relationships. Regression was selected over structural equations modeling because of the complexity of the model and the lack of existing literature-based support for paths from the individual facets of role ambiguity to facets of burnout. Mediation tests consistent with the approach outlined in Baron and Kenny (1986) were performed to determine the contributing role of burnout in linking role ambiguity to corresponding levels of job satisfaction and performance.

6. Results

The first part of the regression analysis provided partial support for H1 (see Table 2). Linkages from two of the individual facets of role ambiguity (boss and customer) to the personal accomplishment facet of burnout were significant ($p < .05$). Role conflict was also significantly linked to personal accomplishment ($p < .05$). However, role ambiguity with work, promotion, family, other managers, and co-workers were not significant ($p > .05$) predictors of personal accomplishment. Overall, results provide partial support for H1. The explained variance for personal accomplishment was .197 up from .08 when only using role conflict as a predictor.

Next, the regression analysis examined antecedents of depersonalization. The customer facet was the only role ambiguity facet significantly related to depersonalization ($p < .05$), thus, partially supporting H2. Role conflict was also found to be significantly ($p < .05$) linked to depersonalization. In keeping with the sequenced process model of burnout within a sales context, personal accomplishment was significantly ($p < .05$) related to depersonalization. The explained variance for depersonalization was .256 up from .123 when using only role conflict.

H3 investigates the antecedents of emotional exhaustion. Support is not found for H3. However, one facet of role ambiguity (customer) was found to be indirectly linked to emotional exhaustion. This linkage was established by means of a mediated relationship with burnout facets of personal accomplishment and depersonalization. Specifically, the direct relationship between customer role ambiguity and emotional exhaustion was initially found to be significant ($p < .05$) without personal accomplishment or depersonalization in the model. However, the relationship became insignificant ($p > .05$) when personal accomplishment and depersonalization were included as predictors in the regression analysis. Hence, support for H6 is found through an indirect relationship between customer role ambiguity and emotional exhaustion that is fully-mediated by personal accomplishment and depersonalization. An indirect effect between role conflict and emotional exhaustion was also found. All of the other role ambiguity facets exhibited neither direct nor indirect relationships to emotional exhaustion. The results fail to support H3, but provide partial support for H6. The explained variance for emotional exhaustion was .428.

The final part of the regression analysis examined direct linkages of multi-faceted role ambiguity to outcome measures of job satisfaction (H4) and performance (H5). Indirect relationships were also analyzed

by means of the burnout facets. Role ambiguity (boss) was directly linked to job satisfaction ($p < .05$), lending partial support to H4. A fully-mediated relationship was found between customer role ambiguity and job satisfaction through burnout; thus, H7 is partially supported. Along with role conflict, role ambiguity with work, promotion, family, other managers, and co-workers were not significantly ($p > .05$) linked to job satisfaction. Moreover, two of the three burnout facets (personal accomplishment and emotional exhaustion) were significantly ($p < .05$) linked to job satisfaction. Moving on to the outcome of job performance, role ambiguity with work, customer, and other managers were significant ($p < .05$) predictors of job performance. Thus, H5 is partially supported. The only burnout facet significantly ($p < .05$) linked to job performance was emotional exhaustion. Burnout was not found to mediate the relationships between role ambiguity and job performance. No support was found for H8. The explained variance for job performance and job satisfaction was .280 and .472, respectively.

7. Discussion and implications

7.1. Discussion

The multi-faceted measure of role ambiguity sheds light on conflicting past findings involving role ambiguity as an antecedent to burnout. Role ambiguity (boss), not role ambiguity (company), was significantly linked to personal accomplishment. Considering that the global role ambiguity scale aligns closely with the company and boss facets (Rhoads et al., 1994; Singh & Rhoads, 1991), we would have found that both of these facets were linked to personal accomplishment if past findings using the global measure were consistent. Seeing that only customer-related role ambiguity is linked to depersonalization and emotional exhaustion, sheds light on inconclusive past findings involving global role ambiguity and these two burnout facets.

Another important finding is the facilitating nature of personal accomplishment and depersonalization, sequenced for a sales context, in linking customer-related role ambiguity and role conflict to emotional exhaustion. Prior studies have not tested these relationships in sequence. Although not the focus of hypothesis development, including role conflict in the testing yielded interesting results. Role conflict has traditionally been tested as a direct predictor of each burnout facet or emotional exhaustion alone, yielding fairly consistent findings. However, when tested in sequence alongside of multi-faceted role ambiguity, role conflict has different results. Contrary to past findings, role conflict exhibits a direct relationship with personal accomplishment. Furthermore, the direct relationship often found between role conflict and emotional exhaustion is actually mediated by personal accomplishment and depersonalization. Also, given that burnout fully mediates the relationship between customer-oriented ambiguity and job satisfaction indicates that uncertainty with clients does not necessarily lead to diminished satisfaction unless burnout is present. Tested at the facet level, these mediation findings are tentative in nature and require future validation.

Surprisingly, not many of the findings of Rhoads et al. (1994) were replicated in this study. Theorizing that internal facets of role ambiguity were more likely to impact the psychologically-based outcome of job satisfaction, Rhoads et al. (1994) found support with internal facets (company, boss, and other managers). On the contrary, results of this study indicate that only the internal facet (boss) is related to job satisfaction. Meanwhile, Rhoads et al. (1994) did not find any internal facets of role ambiguity linked to job performance; whereas, this study found that internal role ambiguity (work and other managers) was significantly related to job performance. The conflicting results between the two studies may possibly be due to the use of different scales for measuring job satisfaction and job performance.

The most interesting finding is the paramount role of customer-oriented ambiguity in a sales context. Customer-oriented ambiguity is the only facet found to be linked to all three facets of burnout and to

both outcome measures. Considering that global role ambiguity was found to have a low correlation with the customer facet of the MULTIRAM scale in the past (Rhoads et al., 1994; Singh & Rhoads, 1991), the importance of customer-related ambiguity established in this study is noteworthy because it indicates that a major component of ambiguity has rarely been captured in prior research. Additionally, all other role ambiguity facets did not exhibit significant relationships with either depersonalization or emotional exhaustion. These two facets are critical in the manifestation of burnout and only one role ambiguity facet (customer) appears to be a predictor.

7.2. Managerial implications

This study has several implications that are highly managerially relevant. Given the negative consequences of burnout including costs related to absenteeism and employee turnover (Cordes & Dougherty, 1993; Lewin & Sager, 2009), having a better understanding of burnout's antecedents and progression can help firms to intervene in a more effective manner. First, this study illustrates that role ambiguity and burnout are multi-faceted phenomena and the specific types and stages are important. Several aspects of role ambiguity may be viewed simply as part of the job and do not necessarily lead to detrimental outcomes. However, ambiguity associated with one's boss contributes to feelings of inadequacy, hence, potentially triggering the onset of burnout. Managers need to mitigate perceptions of ambiguity that may exist among the sales force regarding how they will be evaluated, whether or not they are being heard, and overall managerial expectations. Clear communication from managers in these areas can help salespeople avoid burnout and have higher levels of job satisfaction.

Second, given the boundary-spanning nature of sales, ambiguity associated with customer expectations can be especially troubling. Having a market orientation is important, therefore, time and resources need to be invested in training managers in order to help the sales force maintain positive relationships with customers (Piercy, Cravens, & Lane, 2009). Aspects related to how salespeople give presentations to existing and potential customers can be directly influenced by managers. Sales training should be explicit in identifying company strengths and product benefits that should be communicated with customers. Management should also be proactive in seeking feedback from customers that will help reassure salespeople when feedback is positive, and provide constructive help when feedback is negative, in order to close the perceived expectation gap. Additionally, companies should consider sales training that offers prescriptive steps for handling and overcoming customer objections. Such interventions on the part of management should help reduce salesperson anxiety.

The MULTIRAM instrument and Maslach Burnout inventory are tools that management can periodically administer to the sales force in order to identify and ward off potential problems. Broad in scope, the MULTIRAM instrument allows managers to isolate specific sources of ambiguity and provide targeted interventions. Furthermore, this study shows that heightened levels of ambiguity do not necessarily warrant manager's attention. For instance, ambiguity related to one's family expectations in and of itself does not lead to higher levels of burnout, reduced job satisfaction or reduced performance. This finding mimics the results of Rhoads et al. (1994) and provides additional clarity to the key distinction between conflict and ambiguity. Work-family conflict has been shown to influence levels of emotional exhaustion and job satisfaction in salespeople (Boles et al., 1997; Hamwi et al., 2011; Rutherford et al., 2011). However, simply perceiving that one's family is uncertain about the nature of the job or the fluctuating time commitments involved, does not lead to unwanted consequences. Lastly, it is important for sales managers to recognize that burnout is a progressive syndrome. If assessment indicates that a salesperson is low on the personal accomplishment measure, it should be recognized that this can lead to more advanced stages of burnout including depersonalization

and emotional exhaustion. Yet, once someone has exhibited signs of emotional exhaustion, it may be necessary to not only treat this symptom, but to go back and assess issues with depersonalization and perceptions of inadequacy as well.

7.3. Limitations and future research

This study has some limitations that should be noted. Whereas, the MULTIRAM scale can serve as a robust measure for practitioners, it creates limitations for theory development. The length of the full 45-item MULTIRAM scale limits the inclusion of other associated constructs in a single study. Hence, the items associated with the ethics facet were excluded in this study in favor of including other constructs for analysis. However, given the significance of customer-related ambiguity, this facet should not be excluded in future studies addressing ambiguity among salespeople. Another potential limitation is the conflicting findings of multi-faceted role ambiguity on outcome measures in light of previous research. This may be due to the global measures used in this study for job satisfaction and job performance. As with role ambiguity, job satisfaction is a multi-dimensional construct with emotional exhaustion only affecting certain satisfaction dimensions; and in turn, different satisfaction dimensions affecting various organizational outcomes (Rutherford et al., 2009).

Future research should consider adopting more robust outcome measures perhaps at the expense of dropping non-influential MULTIRAM facets such as family-oriented role ambiguity. It is important to determine whether there is conclusive evidence supporting differential effects of internal versus external dimensions of role ambiguity on various outcome measures. Also, just as burnout has been sequenced for a sales context, role ambiguity needs to be analyzed for potential sequencing. Perhaps ambiguity initiated in certain areas of the job bleeds over into other areas. Levels of ambiguity will likely be perceived differently depending on individual factors. Demographic variables such as age, education, and job experience can be included in future studies of role ambiguity to identify contributing factors (Shepherd et al., 2011).

8. Conclusions

This exploratory study represents an initial attempt to further understand the complex relationships between role ambiguity and salesperson burnout at the individual facet levels. Three primary contributions of this study address gaps in the salesperson burnout literature. First, this study shows that the various types of role ambiguity impact facets of salesperson burnout differently, thus, shedding light on mixed past results. The second contribution is explaining the manner in which burnout links role ambiguity to job satisfaction and job performance at the facet level. Testing the relationships based on the sequencing of burnout in a salesperson context uncovers the mediating role of burnout facets as the syndrome progresses. The final contribution is the importance of customer-oriented ambiguity given its ability to influence job satisfaction and performance as well as all facets of burnout. This finding should encourage sales researchers to assess customer-oriented ambiguity in future studies involving antecedents of burnout.

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